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How Music Can Improve Your Mental Health



By Alexandra Frost

Since her grandfather died five years ago, Casey Clark doesn't go a day without listening to music. It helps her cope with the [grief](#), [depression](#), and symptoms of post-traumatic

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flashbacks are so intense, and I can't get out of them with other grounding techniques," says Clark, 22, a writer who lives in New York City.

The teen and young adult years have long been known as the most pivotal in developing a personal taste in music, and for many, it's the time that music matters the most. The [average teen spends 2.5 hours per day](#) listening to music, and [over half of young adults](#), ages 18 to 29, report streaming music every day (compared to 24% of all adults).

This is good news, because music can be a great way to take care of your [mental health](#).

Music Can Be Distracting and Lower Your Stress

Research suggests that listening to music may lessen the impact of [depression](#) and [anxiety](#). A [2019 study](#) found that college students who listened to classical music every day for two months had significantly lower levels of anxiety.

Another [2016 study](#) looked at the connection between music and anxiety by studying people who have a fear of heights. Participants were put in a virtual reality simulation of riding up nine floors in an elevator. One group listened to music during the experiment, and the other didn't. The researchers found that those who listened to music recovered faster from the [stress](#) of the experience than those who didn't. And many [studies](#) suggest that listening to music can lower stress hormones as well as blood pressure and heart rate (both spike when you're stressed).

When you want music to give you a break from what you're going through, pick songs that have a storyline different from the challenges you're facing, recommends [Bethany Cook](#), PsyD, a psychologist and music therapist in Chicago. This can temporarily

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Music Can Help You Feel Your Feelings

When her clients are in a bad mood, [feeling weird or off](#), or managing difficult emotions, Cook recommends putting on a piece of classical music. “Listening to music that does not have lyrics attached to it lets the listener project their personal feelings and their personal struggle into the music,” she says. And some [research has found](#) that even listening to “sad” music can make you feel some pleasant emotions, which might lessen the pain you are feeling or allow you to more safely feel sad feelings we sometimes try to avoid in life.

Watch: How Music Can Help Hopelessness

Crash Adams: How Music Helped Us Through Hopelessness



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If you don't have the words to explain what you're going through, or if you don't feel comfortable talking about it, song lyrics provide another way to express yourself. Lyrics give you permission to better understand your own situation through someone else's perspective, Cook says. She uses something called "lyric analysis" when she works with kids and teens in group therapy settings. You can try it alone or with a friend or loved one. Here's how:

Bring up the lyrics on your phone(s)

Listen to the song

Mark or highlight words and sentences that stand out to you

Listen to the song again, pausing at the marked places, and discuss or think about why those lyrics spoke to you and how you relate to them

Listen a final time reflecting on your new appreciation of what the song means to you or your friends

Music Can Help You Figure Out Who You Are

Discovering music that resonates is one key way [teens and young adults define who they are and who they want to be](#), says [Michael Viega](#), PhD, a professor of music therapy at Montclair State University in Montclair, New Jersey. Both Viega and Cook strongly encourage parents, teachers, and caregivers to approach teens' and young adults' music with curiosity.

Showing interest in musical taste is a way to show an interest in who a young person is or is becoming. Even listening to music with questionable lyrics is an "opportunity," says

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teenager,” says Viega. “It turned me on to feminist ideals, to ecology and ecological thinking.”

Music Builds Community

Making music — through singing or playing an instrument in school, in a band, or with friends — can connect you with a community of people who share a common interest. And even if you don’t play or sing, you can also find people who share your love for a particular band or type of music. Feeling a sense of belonging to something larger than yourself is a proven way to improve mental health.

Music Can Be a Quick Mood Booster

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Music Can Benefit People Who Are Deaf or Have Hearing Loss

Research into music therapy for people who are deaf and also have mental health disorders is more limited, but [case studies](#) suggest, just as in hearing people, music can help people with hearing loss express emotions and improve cognitive abilities. Cook uses table drums to connect with her deaf cousin. “Table drums are massive, and you can lie underneath them and all of that sound vibration goes straight into your body,” Cook says. Playing them with her cousin has increased their connection and nonverbal communication.

How to Use Music to Feel Better

If you would like to explore using music to help you feel better, Cook and Viega recommend:

Sampling different types of music to expand your horizons and find what you like

Using music as a stress reliever when you are feeling anxious

Discussing meaningful song lyrics with a friend

Trying an instrument

Talking about why you love a particular song with the adults in your life (or, if you’re a caregiver, with your teen)

Listening to classical music when you have confusing or difficult emotions

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